

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF KINGS

Index #
Date of filing:

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JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS,

Plaintiff designates Kings
County as the place of trial

Plaintiff,

Basis of the venue is the Locus
of Occurrence

-against-

THE CITY OF NEW YORK, POLICE OFFICER
JOSEPH ZERELLA and JOHN DOES-Police Officers as
yet unidentified,

SUMMONS

Plaintiff resides at
337 Jamaica Avenue
Brooklyn, New York 11207

Defendants.

County of Kings

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TO THE ABOVE NAMED DEFENDANT:

YOU ARE HEREBY SUMMONED to answer the complaint in this action and to serve a copy of your answer, or, if the complaint is not served with this summons, to serve a notice of appearance, on the Plaintiff's Attorney within 20 days after the service of this summons, exclusive of the day of service (or within 30 days after the service is complete if this summons is not personally delivered to you within the State of New York); and in the case of your failure to appear or answer, judgment will be taken against you by default for the relief demanded herein.

Defendant's address:

THE CITY OF NEW YORK
100 Church Street
New York, New York 10007

Plaintiff's attorneys:

RUBENSTEIN & RYNECKI, ESQS.
16 Court Street, Suite 1717
Brooklyn, New York 11241
(718)522-1020

POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH ZERELLA
c/o New York City Police Department- 75th
Precinct
1000 Sutter Avenue
Brooklyn, New York 11208

Dated: Brooklyn, New York
December 4, 2020

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF KINGS-----X
JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS,

Index No.:

Plaintiff,

COMPLAINT

-against-

THE CITY OF NEW YORK, POLICE OFFICER
JOSEPH ZERELLA and JOHN DOES-Police Officers as
yet unidentified,Defendants.
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Plaintiff, by his attorneys, RUBENSTEIN & RYNECKI, ESQS., complaining of the defendants herein, upon information and belief, respectfully shows to this Court, and alleges as follows:

**AS AND FOR A FIRST CAUSE OF ACTION FOR ASSAULT
AND BATTERY ON BEHALF OF JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS**

1. That at all times hereinafter mentioned, the plaintiff was and still is a resident of the County of Kings, City and State of New York.
2. That all times hereinafter mentioned, the defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, was and still is a municipal corporation, duly organized and existing pursuant to the laws of the State of New York.
3. That the defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, maintains a police force known as the NEW YORK CITY POLICE DEPARTMENT.
4. That prior hereto on April 12, 2020, and within the time prescribed by law, a sworn Notice of Claim stating, among other things, the time when and place where the injuries and damages were sustained, together with plaintiff's demands for adjustment or payment thereof, was served and that thereafter THE CITY OF NEW YORK, refused or neglected for more than (30) days and up to the commencement of this action to make any adjustment or payment thereof, and that thereafter, and within the time provided by law, this action was commenced.

5. Pursuant to the General Municipal Law, the Statutory 50-H Hearing of the plaintiff was held on June 24, 2020.

6. That on January 22, 2020, and at all times hereinafter mentioned and upon information and belief, the defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, employed POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH ZERELLA and JOHN DOES-Police Officers as yet unidentified, as police officers, agents, servants and/or employees.

7. That on January 22, 2020, and at all times hereinafter mentioned and upon information and belief, the plaintiff, JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS, was lawfully present at or about the premises located at 83 Van Siclen Avenue, in the County of Kings, City and State of New York.

8. That on January 22, 2020, and at all times hereinafter mentioned and upon information and belief, while at the aforementioned location, the plaintiff, JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS, was approached and was assaulted and battered by the defendants POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH ZERELLA and JOHN DOES-Police Officers as yet unidentified. The assault and battery consisted of being tackled to the ground, jumped on, beaten, pushed into the pavement face down and was forcefully placed in handcuffs. The plaintiff was arrested and taken under police custody and was taken to the 75th Precinct and was held in a holding cell for a period of time. The plaintiff was transported to Brookdale Hospital, for treatment of his injuries. On January 23, 2020 at approximately 1:00 p.m., the plaintiff was taken to Kings County Central Brooking and was held until his release at approximately 3:00 a.m., on January 24, 2020.

9. That on January 22, 2020, and at all times hereinafter mentioned and upon information and belief, plaintiff, JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS, was assaulted and battered by defendants, POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH ZERELLA and JOHN DOES-Police Officers as yet unidentified, who were acting within the scope of their employment with the defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, at the aforesaid location.

10. That on January 22, 2020, and at all times hereinafter mentioned and upon information and belief, the aforementioned assault and battery was performed knowingly, intentionally and willfully.

11. That on January 22, 2020, and at all times hereinafter mentioned and upon information and belief, the defendants, POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH ZERELLA and JOHN DOES-Police Officers as yet unidentified, who committed the aforementioned assault and battery upon the plaintiff, JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS, were acting within the scope of their employment with the defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK.

12. That on January 22, 2020, and at all times hereinafter mentioned and upon information and belief, the assault and battery on the plaintiff was without probable cause and was not the result of an appropriate arrest.

13. By reason of said assault and battery the plaintiff was caused to suffer severe and serious injuries in and about diverse parts of the person, and suffered great pain, distress, mental shock, mental anguish and psychological trauma and was otherwise injured.

14. By the reason of the foregoing, the plaintiff, JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS, sustained damages in an amount exceeding the jurisdictional limits of all the lower Courts.

**AS AND FOR A SECOND CAUSE OF ACTION FOR NEGLIGENT
HIRING AND RETENTION ON BEHALF OF JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS**

15. The plaintiff repeats and realleges each and every allegation set forth above numbered "1" through "14" inclusive with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

16. That the defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, did not exercise reasonable care and diligence in the selection, engagement, employment and training of their police officers, agents, servants, and employees and were negligent in the hiring, training and retention of the defendants, POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH ZERELLA and JOHN DOES-Police Officers as yet unidentified, who assaulted, battered and violated the civil rights of the plaintiff, JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS.

17. That the defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, had prior knowledge of the inappropriate, unlawful, and improper conduct of the defendants, POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH ZERELLA and JOHN DOES-Police Officers as yet unidentified, and continued to employ them and allowed them to be in contact with the public at large.

18. By the reason of the foregoing, the plaintiff, JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS, sustained damages in an amount exceeding the jurisdictional limits of all the lower Courts.

**AS AND FOR A THIRD CAUSE OF ACTION FOR FALSE
ARREST ON BEHALF OF JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS**

19. The plaintiff repeats and realleges each and every allegation set forth above numbered "1" through "18" inclusive with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

20. That on January 22, 2020, and at all times hereinafter mentioned and upon information and belief, defendants, POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH ZERELLA and JOHN DOES-Police Officers as yet unidentified, were working within the scope of their employment and authority with the defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, when they arrested and confined the plaintiff, JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS.

21. That on January 22, 2020, and at all times hereinafter mentioned and upon information and belief, the arrest and confinement was without probable cause nor based on reasonable grounds and not founded upon an arrest warrant.

22. That as a result of the aforesaid false arrest and confinement, the plaintiff, JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS, sustained serious permanent personal injuries along with humiliation, shame, indignity, damage to reputation and credit and suffered emotional and physical distress, emotional distress and injuries.

23. By the reason of the foregoing, the plaintiff, JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS, sustained damages in an amount exceeding the jurisdictional limits of all the lower Courts.

**AS AND FOR A FOURTH CAUSE OF ACTION FOR FALSE
IMPRISONMENT ON BEHALF OF JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS**

24. The plaintiff repeats and realleges each and every allegation set forth above numbered "1 through "23" inclusive with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

25. That on January 22, 2020, and at all times hereinafter mentioned and upon information and belief, defendants, POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH ZERELLA and JOHN DOES-Police Officers as yet unidentified, were acting within the scope of their employment when they, without justification and without probable cause, imprisoned the plaintiff, JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS.

26. That the defendants, POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH ZERELLA and JOHN DOES-Police Officers as yet unidentified, while acting within the scope of their employment, intentionally confined the plaintiff, JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS, against his will and said confinement was not privileged.

27. By the reason of the foregoing, the plaintiff, JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS, sustained damages in an amount exceeding the jurisdictional limits of all the lower Courts.

**AS AND FOR A FIFTH CAUSE OF ACTION FOR INTENTIONAL
AND NEGLIGENT INFLICTION OF EMOTIONAL
DISTRESS ON BEHALF OF JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS**

28. The plaintiff repeats and realleges each and every allegation set forth above numbered "1" through "27" inclusive with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

29. That the defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, including but not limited to POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH ZERELLA and JOHN DOES-Police Officers as yet unidentified, acted intentionally, recklessly and with utter disregard to the consequences of their actions and caused severe emotional distress to the plaintiff through their actions.

30. Said actions exceeded all reasonable bounds of decency, were outrageous and shocking and resulted in severe emotional distress to the plaintiff, JORDAN K. BLAKE-

MATHEWS.

31. That as a result of said intentional and negligent acts, the plaintiff, JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS, become sick, sore, lame and disabled, received severe and serious injuries in and about diverse parts of his person and suffered great physical pain, distress, mental shock, mental anguish and psychological trauma and was otherwise injured.

32. By reason of the foregoing, the plaintiff, JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS, sustained damages in an amount exceeding the jurisdictional limits of all the lower Courts.

**AS AND FOR A SIXTH CAUSE OF ACTION FOR CIVIL
RIGHTS VIOLATION ON BEHALF OF JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS**

33. The plaintiff repeats and realleges each and every allegation set forth above numbered "1" through "32" inclusive with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

34. The defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, through policies, practices and customs, directly caused the constitutional violation suffered by plaintiff, JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS.

35. The defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, through its police department, has had and still has hiring practices that it knows will lead to the hiring of the police officers, including but not limited to POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH ZERELLA and JOHN DOES-Police Officers as yet unidentified, lacking the intellectual capacity and moral fortitude to discharge their duties in accordance with the constitution and is indifferent to the consequences.

36. The defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, through its police department, has *de facto quota* policy that encourages unlawful stops, unlawful searches, false arrests, the fabrication of evidence and perjury.

37. The defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, at all relevant times, was, upon information and belief, aware that these individual defendants, including but not limited to POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH ZERELLA and JOHN DOES-Police Officers as yet unidentified,

routinely commit constitutional violations such as those at issue here and has failed to change its policies, practices and customs to stop this behavior.

38. The defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, at all relevant times, was aware that these individual defendants, including but not limited to POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH ZERELLA and JOHN DOES-Police Officers as yet unidentified, are unfit officers who have previously committed the acts alleged herein and/or have a propensity for unconstitutional conduct.

39. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, the plaintiff, JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS, sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

**AS AND FOR A SEVENTH CAUSE OF ACTION FOR
PUNITIVE DAMAGES ON BEHALF OF JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS**

40. The plaintiff repeats and realleges each and every allegation set forth above numbered "1" through "39" inclusive with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

41. The actions of the defendants herein-above alleged, were malicious, willful and grossly negligent.

42. That the defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, authorized, permitted and ratified the unlawful and negligent acts of their agents, servants and/or employees, including but not limited to POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH ZERELLA and JOHN DOES-Police Officers as yet unidentified, herein-above alleged.

43. By the reason of the foregoing, the plaintiff, JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS, sustained damages in an amount exceeding the jurisdictional limits of all the lower Courts.

WHEREFORE, plaintiff, JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS, demands judgment both compensatory and exemplary in an amount exceeding the jurisdictional limits of all lower Courts on the **First** Cause of Action; plaintiff, JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS, demands judgment

both compensatory and exemplary in an amount exceeding the jurisdictional limits of all lower Courts on the **Second** Cause of Action; plaintiff, JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS, demands judgment both compensatory and exemplary in an amount exceeding the jurisdictional limits of all lower Courts on the **Third** Cause of Action; plaintiff, plaintiff, JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS, demands judgment both compensatory and exemplary in an amount exceeding the jurisdictional limits of all lower Courts on the **Fourth** Cause of Action; plaintiff, JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS, demands judgment both compensatory and exemplary in an amount exceeding the jurisdictional limits of all lower Courts on the **Fifth** Cause of Action; plaintiff, JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS, demands judgment both compensatory and exemplary in an amount exceeding the jurisdictional limits of all lower Courts on the **Sixth** Cause of Action; plaintiff, JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS, demands judgment both compensatory and exemplary in an amount exceeding the jurisdictional limits of all lower Courts on the **Seventh** Cause of Action; together with attorneys' fees, and the costs and disbursements of this action.

DATED: Brooklyn, New York
December 4, 2020

Yours, etc.


ROBERT MIJUCA, ESQ.
RUBENSTEIN & RYNECKI, ESQS.
Attorneys for Plaintiff
JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS
16 Court Street Suite 1717
Brooklyn, New York 11241
(718) 522-1020
File No.: 20JB01-22

INDIVIDUAL VERIFICATION

STATE OF NEW YORK)

) SS:

COUNTY OF KINGS)

JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS, being duly sworn, deposes and says, that deponent is the plaintiff in the within action; that deponent has read the foregoing **COMPLAINT** and knows the contents hereof; that the same is true to deponent's own knowledge, except as to the matters therein stated to be alleged upon information and belief, and that as to those matters deponent believes them to be true.



JORDAN K. BLAKE-MATHEWS

Sworn to before me this 10th
day of December 2020



NOTARY PUBLIC

MAGDA MARIN-COLON
Notary Public, State of New York
No. 01MA6158891
Qualified in Richmond County
Commission Expires ~~1-10-20~~ 23